

August 13, 2026

Cigna Healthcare
Cigna Appeals Unit
P.O. Box 188011
Chattanooga, TN 37422

RE: Formal Appeal of Claim Denial — Mohamed Hermann (MRN MUSC1465392), Claim MUSC-BC1F-2

Patient	Mohamed Hermann (DOB 1996-10-29)
MRN	MUSC1465392
Member ID / Group	CIG627241918 / GRP-90544
Claim number	MUSC-BC1F-2
Date of service	2026-03-31
Procedure billed	CPT 99214 — Office/outpatient visit, established patient, moderate complexity
Primary diagnosis	J06.9 — Acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified
Denied amount	\$415.38
Denial code	CARC 204 / RARC N130 — This service/equipment/drug is not covered under the patient's current benefit plan.
Appeal deadline	2026-11-15

Dear Appeals Review Committee:

SUMMARY OF APPEAL

MUSC Health is submitting this formal first-level appeal on behalf of patient Mohamed Hermann (MRN: MUSC1465392, Member ID: CIG627241918, Group: GRP-90544) regarding the denial of Claim MUSC-BC1F-2 for services rendered on March 31, 2026, at MUSC Health University Medical Center. The claim was submitted on April 15, 2026, and denied on May 19, 2026, under CARC 204 ("This service/equipment/drug is not covered under the patient's current benefit plan") and RARC N130 ("Consult plan benefit documents/guidelines for information about restrictions for this service"), with the payer remark stating: "Service is excluded under the member's plan benefit document." MUSC Health respectfully disputes this determination and requests full reconsideration and payment of the billed amount of \$415.38.

CLINICAL BACKGROUND

On March 31, 2026, Dr. Sarah E. Whitmore, MD (NPI 1447382910) evaluated Mr. Hermann, a 29-year-old established male patient, in an on-campus outpatient hospital setting (Place of Service 22) for an acute upper respiratory infection (ICD-10 J06.9), with a secondary diagnosis of R69. The encounter was appropriately coded as CPT 99214, representing an office or outpatient visit for an established patient requiring moderate-complexity medical decision-making. One unit was billed under revenue code 0510 at a total charge of \$415.38. Cigna Healthcare's own adjudication recognized an allowed amount of \$257.84, which confirms the service falls within a recognized fee schedule and was not denied on the basis of coding error or lack of authorization.

BASIS FOR APPEAL

The denial of this claim on benefit-exclusion grounds is not supported by the facts of this case. CPT 99214 is a standard evaluation and management service representing a medically necessary outpatient visit for an acute illness. Acute upper respiratory infections are common, time-sensitive conditions requiring clinical assessment, and the provision of such care by a qualified physician in an outpatient hospital setting is consistent with generally accepted standards of medical practice. The fact that Cigna calculated an allowed amount of \$257.84 strongly indicates that this service type is recognized under the plan's fee schedule and is not categorically excluded. A benefit exclusion determination that simultaneously acknowledges an allowed amount is internally inconsistent and warrants immediate review.

Furthermore, Mr. Hermann's coverage under the Cigna Healthcare Advantage plan (Group GRP-90544) is active through December 31, 2026, encompassing the March 31, 2026, date of service. No information in the denial correspondence identifies a specific benefit exclusion provision applicable to evaluation and management services for acute illness in an outpatient hospital setting. MUSC Health respectfully requests that Cigna provide the precise benefit document language and exclusion clause upon which this denial is based, as required under applicable appeal-rights obligations, so that any remaining dispute may be addressed with full transparency.

REQUESTED ACTION

MUSC Health requests that Cigna Healthcare overturn the denial of Claim MUSC-BC1F-2 and reprocess the claim for payment in accordance with the contracted allowed amount. Should Cigna require additional clinical documentation, operative notes, or medical records to complete this review, MUSC Health will provide them promptly upon request. This appeal is submitted in advance of the November 15, 2026, appeal deadline via the designated submission channels. If this first-level appeal is not resolved in favor of the provider, MUSC Health reserves the right to pursue all available levels of appeal, including external independent review.

Respectfully submitted,

Angela R. Whitfield, RN, BSN, CPC

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Enclosures

- Remittance advice / explanation of payment
- Itemized claim detail (UB-04 / CMS-1500)
- Relevant clinical documentation from the medical record